

On-Call Handoff Checklist

Run through this checklist at the start of every shift and again at the end. The goal is zero-surprise handoffs: the incoming engineer should not be paged for something the outgoing engineer already knew about.

At the start of your shift

- Read the last 24 hours of #incident and #ops channels.
- Confirm all active alerts are either resolved, acknowledged, or have a tracking ticket.
- Check the deploy calendar for upcoming changes during your window.
- Verify your paging device is online by sending a test page to yourself.
- Confirm VPN, kubectrl, AWS console, and Grafana access all work BEFORE you need them.
- Review any open postmortem action items that touch services you cover.

Mid-shift hygiene

- After every page: write a one-line note for the next engineer.
- Update any runbook you used if a step was wrong or missing.
- Close out any silences you opened before they expire silently.

At the end of your shift

- Post a handoff summary in #oncall-handoff including: open incidents, suspicious metrics, planned deploys, anything you 'wouldn't be surprised to see page tonight'.
- Acknowledge that the next engineer has seen and accepted the handoff. Do not leave the channel before that.
- If you opened any silences during your shift, list them with their expiry times.

Refusal to hand off

If an incident is active at the end of your shift, you do NOT hand off until you have explicit acknowledgement from the incoming engineer that they are now the incident commander. Silent handoffs during a live incident are a known cause of customer impact.